

Dirassat & Abhath
The Arabic Journal of Human
and Social Sciences



مجلة دراسات وأبحاث
المجلة العربية في العلوم الإنسانية
والاجتماعية

EISSN: 2253-0363
ISSN : 1112-9751

Factors Influencing the Teaching and Learning of Foreign Languages

العوامل المؤثرة في تعليم وتعلم اللغات الأجنبية

Djoudi Sayah

Professor lecteure A, University A.Mira Bejaia , djoudi.sayah@univ-bejaia.dz.

جودي صياح

أستاذ محاضر، جامعة عبد الرحمان ميرة بجاية، كلية اللغات والأداب، قسم اللغة والأدب العربي،

djoudi.sayah@univ-bejaia.dz

تاريخ القبول : 2025/12/27

تاريخ الاستلام: 2025/07/07

Abstract:

This study aims to shed light on the factors that influence and support the teaching and learning of foreign languages. Most recent research has focused on these effective elements in the process of foreign language teaching and learning, with the goal of improving the level of foreign language teaching in Algeria. Therefore, this study seeks to highlight these factors and explore how they contribute to the teaching-learning process, in order to ensure their proper and effective use in the field of foreign language teaching, particularly in Algeria. To what extent do these factors impact foreign language teaching and learning, and how effective are they.

Keywords: teaching, learning, foreign language, factors.

المخلص: تتلخص هذه الدراسة في تسليط الضوء على العوامل المؤثرة والمساعدة في تعليم اللغات الأجنبية وتعلمها، إذ ركزت جل الدراسات الحديثة على هذا العنصر الفعال في تعليم اللغات الأخرى وتعلمها، من أجل النهوض بمستوى تعليم اللغات الأجنبية ولاسيما في الجزائر، لذا تهدف هذه الدراسة إلى إبراز هذه العوامل، ومعرفة كيفية إسهامها في العملية التعليمية، من أجل الاهتمام بها واستخدامها بشكل سليم بطرق سليمة وناجحة في ميدان تعليم اللغات الأجنبية لاسيما في الجزائر. فما هي درجة تأثير هذه العوامل في تعليم وتعلم اللغات الأجنبية ومدى فعاليتها.

الكلمات المفتاحية: التعليم، التعلم، اللغات الأجنبية، العوامل.

1. INTRODUCTION

In today's world, the teaching and learning of foreign languages has become an urgent necessity, driven by the rapid and unprecedented advancements in various domains. To keep pace with this scientific and technological progress, Arab societies must prioritize the enhancement of educational quality—both in first language teaching and foreign languages teaching. Education plays a fundamental role in shaping individuals equipped with modern knowledge and technological skills, and in integrating these competencies into the teaching process. Such integration contributes significantly to improving the quality of education, responding to the demands of the modern age, and fulfilling societal hopes and ambitions.

In this context, many leading nations have introduced foreign language teaching at an early age, a trend increasingly adopted by Arab countries as well. This shift has been reinforced by the growing body of research in fields such as psycholinguistics, sociolinguistics, and cognitive psychology, which has laid the foundation for specialized studies in second and foreign language acquisition. It paved the way for specialized studies in the field of second and foreign

language learning, as well as the application of their findings and the development and improvement of teaching methods¹. Current research consistently demonstrates that younger learners tend to acquire languages more efficiently, which underscores the urgent need to cultivate learners with a solid foundation in foreign language competence from an early stage.

2. Terminological Overview

2.1 Foreign Language:

The teaching of foreign languages thus holds a prominent place in contemporary educational research and policy. Mastery of foreign languages enables individuals to engage with the global community and to appreciate diverse cultures. In Algeria, French and English are the two primary foreign languages taught. They are introduced at both the primary and secondary levels of education and are formally recognized as foreign languages. Moreover, both languages are offered as academic disciplines at the university level throughout the country.¹

A *foreign language* is the second language learned by a student during the second cycle of basic education in public schools, in addition to their original or first language. Foreign language education refers to the

teaching of one or more foreign languages alongside the native language, with the aim of broadening the learner's conceptual and cognitive horizons. Through this process, learners develop the ability to understand the world and their surroundings. Each country adopts its own approach to foreign language teaching. English holds the leading position globally as the most widely taught foreign language, due to its status as the language of science, technology, and international communication.

In Algeria, French is considered the primary foreign language, largely due to historical factors—namely, the prolonged period of French colonial rule. More recently, English has been introduced into the primary school curriculum, in line with the Algerian government's broader educational reform strategy. This initiative reflects future-oriented aspirations to modernize and enhance the national education system, helping it to flourish and advance. The introduction of English at an early stage also aims to expand children's cognitive capacities and equip them with a range of intellectual and social benefits.

2.2 Problems :

In classical Arabic, Ibn Manẓūr defines a *problem* (*mushkil*) as something ambiguous or unclear: "The matter became problematic when it became confused or obscure; a 'problem' is something perplexing and ambiguous." Likewise, 'Abd Allāh 'Uthmān al-Mughīrah defines a problem as "a puzzling question or a confusing situation that cannot be answered or resolved using the ready-made knowledge or skills possessed by the person facing it."²

2.3 Learning :

Learning is commonly defined as "a change in performance that occurs under the condition of practice, along with the influence of reinforcement, motivation, and method." Mursell described it as a process that "entails a continuous improvement in performance, with this improvement being observable through changes occurring during the learning process itself. It involves exploring behavioral situations without

necessarily enabling full control over the phenomenon."³

Gates defined learning as "the acquisition of various means that help satisfy needs and achieve goals," often manifesting in the context of problem-solving.

In 1970, Gagné offered a definition stating that "a learning event occurs when a situation provides stimuli or cues that affect the learner in such a way that their behaviour changes from one state before the event to another state afterward. This change in performance is what leads us to conclude that learning has taken place."⁴

There are a number of well-established facts that have been the subject of observation, research, and experimentation. The first of these affirms that all aspects of human development depend—at least to some extent—on multiple factors, including those related to internal growth or maturation, and others stemming from the external environment. The second fact posits that learning, understood as a modification of behavior resulting from experience and practice, is itself a manifestation of development.

A third important finding highlights the interaction between maturation and experience to such a degree that it becomes difficult for educators to clearly distinguish between behaviors attributable to learning and those resulting from natural maturation. The fourth fact points to individual differences in the ability to learn, to adapt to new situations, to manipulate objects and ideas, and to relate to others.

2.4 Education:

Education is a process through which the teacher actively engages with learners, producing meaningful and constructive outcomes through direct interaction. This process may take place within formal educational institutions or in informal settings. Education is holistic in nature, encompassing skills, knowledge, and experience. The term *education* also refers to any process that involves learning, whether it occurs intentionally or unintentionally. Learning may be pre-planned and

systematically implemented, or it may happen spontaneously—without prior intention—through incidental acquisition of knowledge and behavior.

2.5 Learning, Education, and Teaching :

There is a conceptual distinction between *learning* and *teaching*. *Teaching* refers to the act of instruction or transmission of knowledge carried out by a teacher to a learner.⁶ In contrast, *learning* is a psychological process that takes place when the learner's mind actively engages with educational content. Learning signifies a dynamic stage through which curriculum objectives, knowledge, and activities are internalized and transformed into tangible and observable behavior on the part of the learners.

Teaching is a social process whereby learning content—whether information, values, movements, or experience—is transmitted from a sender, typically referred to as the teacher, to a receiver, the student.⁷

The concepts of *learning*, *education*, and *teaching* are interrelated, yet they may be distinguished by the nature of the interaction between the learner, the teacher, and the subject matter, or by the clarity of instructional objectives. High-level cognitive interaction is characteristic of *teaching*, while *education* involves a broader interaction that may occur with less clearly defined goals. In contrast, *learning* relies heavily on the learner's own initiative, and on the process of acquiring and internalizing knowledge—ultimately the final aim of all teaching and education. It also serves as the theoretical starting point for both.

Since the discussion is framed in its historical context, it is important to consider the developments that led to the emergence of *education* as a distinct process from *learning*. Initially, learning occurred through observation alone; however, this proved insufficient with the rise of symbolic knowledge, abstract concepts, and indirect experience. Humans first learned independently, before being taught or instructed by others. Adults later assumed the

roles of educators and instructors to facilitate their children's learning.⁵

The overlap and interaction between *teaching* and *education* have become so pronounced that a clear-cut distinction between them remains unresolved—particularly with the increasing prevalence of self-directed learning in modern life. This evolving landscape calls for more precise criteria concerning educational goals, curricula, and learning activities in order to clearly differentiate between the three concepts.

3. Factors Affecting Foreign Language Learning

The essential components of the educational process—teacher, learner, and content—are inherently interconnected and mutually influential. The teacher brings the necessary competencies; the learner demonstrates receptiveness (through maturation, readiness, and motivation); and the content is shaped by various mechanisms, foundations, and objectives, all aimed at achieving specific learning outcomes. Numerous factors influence the effectiveness of foreign language learning and teaching. These factors can be psychological or social, and the learning process is contingent upon several conditions such as *maturation*, *aptitude*, and *motivation*.

a. Maturation

Maturation refers to the psychological and physiological changes that occur independently of formal learning or training. These changes are attributed to genetic and biological influences. Maturation and learning are interrelated and represent two facets of the same developmental process—that of individual growth and progression.⁹ For example, a child's acquisition of speech is a form of learning, but the capacity to engage in such learning is rooted in maturation.

b. Aptitude

Aptitude encompasses both socio-cultural and individual motivational factors that influence the learner's willingness to engage with the learning process. It involves curiosity, problem-solving abilities, and the learner's intrinsic drive to acquire knowledge.

Readiness to learn depends on the degree of cognitive stimulation and practice a learner receives. Aptitude manifests in organized activity undertaken by the individual to achieve set goals.⁶

By *organized activity*, we mean inquiry, investigation, and research guided by a mental framework consisting primarily of hypotheses. The learner uses these hypotheses to explore, validate, or refute them, relying on tools, methods, and strategies that move them from uncertainty and doubt to clarity, conviction, and discovery.

c. Motivation

Motivation is the internal force that energizes, directs, and sustains a learner's behavior toward achieving a specific goal. Since it is an internal phenomenon, motivation cannot be directly observed, but it can be inferred from learner's external behaviours. If the learner displays active, engaged, and goal-oriented behavior, one can assume that they are motivated. Conversely, behavior that is sluggish, hesitant, disorganized, and lacks direction signals a lack of motivation, which is detrimental to learning. While motivations vary in intensity and influence, the most critical point remains that *no learning occurs in the absence of motivation*.⁷

Many studies and research findings have demonstrated the crucial role that motivation plays in the processes of teaching and learning. It is regarded as "a psychological and social factor often used to explain exceptional success in second language learning. This factor is intuitively appealing, as it is widely accepted that individuals who are motivated acquire a second language more quickly and more effectively."¹² Motivation is thus an internal driving force that stimulates the learner, encouraging them to concentrate their attention and exert effort in pursuit of knowledge.

Certain psychological studies suggest that humans are naturally inclined toward curiosity, discovery, and the enjoyment of learning new and useful things. This innate curiosity is closely linked to motivation.

According to Jerome Bruner, "curiosity is the earliest form of intrinsic motivation. Our attention is drawn to things that are unclear, incomplete, or uncertain. The pursuit of clarity—or even the effort to achieve it—is what satisfies us and fulfills our need."⁸

Learning is typically measured or inferred through observable aspects of behaviour. Psychologists generally base their conclusions about learning on two main foundations. First, they acknowledge the existence of what is called an independent variable, which must be manipulated either conceptually or through behaviour. In other words, for a living organism to learn, it must engage in practice or experience. Common indicators of such practice include the number of repetitions or responses. A second requirement is the identification of a dependent variable that reflects the outcomes of this practice or experience. Of course, the most appropriate measurement tool will vary depending on the specific learning context.⁹

d. Language

Language is a social phenomenon and a uniquely human faculty acquired from the social environment in which an individual lives. It both influences and is influenced by that environment, serving as a gateway to interpersonal interaction and integration into society. Throughout history, language has played a central role in human life, as it is through language that individuals articulate their thoughts and emotions into words comprehensible to others. Given the significance of language in both individual and collective life—whether the mother tongue or a foreign language—its instruction has long been the focus of extensive attention, with every effort made to facilitate the process, particularly in the context of foreign language education.

Language plays a fundamental role in human learning. It is therefore useful to study this uniquely human aptitude in depth. Many thinkers regard humans as rational and linguistic beings. For many researchers, the relationship between thought and language is indisputable. The central question, however, concerns whether thought is dependent on

language, or whether this dependency pertains only to certain types of thought.

In the field of foreign language instruction, particularly at the middle school level, learners begin to show increased word recognition speed, improved pronunciation accuracy, and expanded lexical knowledge. Their silent reading pace accelerates, oral reading performance improves, and comprehension becomes more precise. The teacher plays a critical role in developing each of these skills through engaging pedagogical methods. Introducing the topic should arouse curiosity about the meanings to be explored, followed by opportunities for students to engage in silent reading aimed at comprehension. This is typically followed by discussion questions to assess and deepen students' understanding of the main ideas, all conducted in the target language.

4. Social and Educational Factors

a. The Family

There is no doubt that the family is the learner's first environment and initial point of contact with the world. It is the primary factor in shaping and nurturing the child's personality. The family serves as the foundation for linguistic, psychological, and social development. It is important to note that the family's educational background can significantly influence a child's acquisition of a foreign language—especially if one family member already possesses proficiency in the same language being taught at school. This can help create a form of linguistic immersion, if the term may be used. For this reason, families must assume various roles to support the child and facilitate the learning process.¹⁰

b. The School

The school is the second environment the child encounters after the family. It provides a supportive setting for healthy linguistic development. This role arises from both social and linguistic necessity, as the school equips the child with knowledge and skills across various fields of science and learning. It is within this context that talents are discovered, the child's intellectual personality develops, and their strengths and

weaknesses emerge—weaknesses that the child then strives to overcome.¹¹

At school, the learner is introduced to standard (formal) language and to foreign languages. They also learn about the cultures of other nations and expand their vocabulary, expressions, and syntactic structures in the target language.¹²

The school also plays a vital role in foreign language instruction, a task that is especially crucial in today's fast-paced, knowledge-driven world, where individuals must master more than one language to fully understand their surroundings. This is the school's mission: to educate every individual, shaping informed, cultured citizens who contribute positively to society and who are familiar with their culture and the experiences of previous generations, particularly through the transmission of cultural heritage.

5. CONCLUSION

In conclusion, this study has addressed a topic of great significance. Among its key findings are the following:

1. The factors that facilitate the teaching and learning of foreign languages have a significant impact on the educational process.
2. Motivation is a cornerstone of teaching and learning. It serves as a key indicator in understanding success and language proficiency.¹³
3. Maturation and readiness are both essential in the teaching and learning of foreign languages, as they enhance learning effectiveness.

6. Recommendations

- Provide a suitable environment for teaching by taking into account the various factors influencing foreign language teaching and learning.
- Organize intensive and well-structured training programs for foreign language teachers to ensure high-quality instruction.
- Create immersive language environments for foreign language learners by encouraging direct interaction with proficient speakers and integrating modern technology and distance learning tools.

8. Bibliography List :

1. -Aqla Al-Samadi and Fawaz Muhammad Abdul-Haq, (2003) Theories of Language Learning and Acquisition, Implications for Learning and Teaching Arabic, Yarmouk University
2. Al-Ahmad Amal:(2001) Research and Studies in Psychology, Al-Risala Foundation, Beirut.
3. Abdul Hamid Jaber: (1999) Teaching and Learning Strategies, Dar Al-Fikr Al-Arabi, Cairo, Egypt, Series of References in Education and Psychology, Book 10,.
4. Ali Muhammad Hussein: (1987) Understanding Arithmetic, Students' Understanding of the Four Arithmetic Operations in Primary School, Arab Publishing and Distribution House, Amman, Jordan, 1st edition.
5. Abdul Hamid Jaber: (1999) Teaching and Learning Strategies, Dar Al-Fikr Al-Arabi, Cairo, Egypt, Series of References in Education and Psychology, Book 10.
6. Dolinsky Richard: (1987) The Psychology of Human Learning, translated by Dr. Ralph Rizkallah, University Foundation for Studies and Publishing, Beirut, 1st edition.
7. Fatim Lutfi Muhammad et al: (1988) Contemporary Learning Theories and Their Educational Applications, Maktabat Al-Nahda Al-Masriya, Cairo.
8. Susan M. Jas and Larry Selinker, (2009) Second Language Acquisition: A General Introduction, translated by Majid al-Hamad, King Saud University, King Fahd National Library Catalogue (DAT)
9. Tawq Muhyiddin: (1984) Fundamentals of Educational Psychology, John Wiley & Sons, New York, 3rd edition,
7. **Références ;**
1-Aqla Al-Samadi and Fawaz Muhammad Abdul-Haq, Theories of Language Learning and Acquisition, Implications for Learning and Teaching Arabic, Yarmouk University,p13
- 2- Baali Al-Sharif Hafsa, Education, Journal of the Researcher in Humanities and Social Sciences, Vol. 1, 2010,p22
- 3- Al-Ahmad Amal: Research and Studies in Psychology, Al-Risala Foundation, Beirut, 2001,p61.
- 4- Ibn Manzur: Lisan al-Arab, Part Seven, Beirut, Dar Ihya al-Turath al-Arabi, 1st edition, 1996, p189.
- 5- Tawq Muhyiddin et al.: Fundamentals of Educational Psychology, John Wiley & Sons, New York, 3rd edition, 1984, p37
- 6- Dolinsky, Richard: The Psychology of Human Learning, translated by Dr. Ralph Rizkallah, University Foundation for Studies and Publishing, Beirut, 1st edition, 1987, p11-12.
- 7- Abdul Hamid Jaber: Teaching and Learning Strategies, Dar Al-Fikr Al-Arabi, Cairo, Egypt, Series of References in Education and Psychology, Book 10, 1999, p48.
- 8- Al-Issawi Abdul Rahman Muhammad: Educational Psychology, Studies in Education – Review Issues, Dar Al-Nahda Al-Arabiya, Beirut, 1st edition, 2004, p229.
- 9- Fatim Lutfi Muhammad et al.: Contemporary Learning Theories and Their Educational Applications, Maktabat Al-Nahda Al-Masriya, Cairo, 1st edition, 1988, p82.
- 10- Fakhr al-Din Nasir Younis: Principles of Teaching, Damascus University Publications, 2nd edition, 1999, p18.
- 11- Susan M. Jas and Larry Selinker, Second Language Acquisition: A General Introduction, translated by Majid al-Hamad, King Saud University, King Fahd National Library Catalogue (DAT), 2009, p72.
- 12- Abdullah Othman Al-Mughira: Methods of Teaching Mathematics, Deanship of Library Affairs, Riyadh, King Saud University, 1st edition. 1988,p155.
- 13- Stuart Halls: The Psychology of Learning, translated by Fouad Abu Hatab, Amal Sadiq, MacGraw-Hill Publishing, New York. 1983.p88